What you switch on, and what it costs you to switch on

Cowork is off by default and the way it is turned on changed at general availability. The old per-agent allow list is deprecated; access now comes from spending policy.

Before anyone can open Cowork

- A Microsoft 365 Copilot license for the user.
- Usage-based billing enabled in the tenant. Cowork is off until it is.
- A spending policy that selects Cowork: admin center, Copilot, Cost management.
- The user in scope of that policy. Cowork is limited to Anthropic-supported regions.

The thing that catches people out

- A spending policy is an access control, not only a budget.
- Any user in scope who selects Cowork can use it, however small the limit. One credit still grants access.
- To keep someone out, leave them out of every policy that selects Cowork. Do not lower their limit.
- Enforcement is asynchronous, so a cap is not an instant stop.

Rolling these skills out

- Each user uploads their own. There is no tenant-wide install for a custom skill.
- A user can hold 50 custom skills and 25 scheduled prompts. Skills are cheap; schedules are scarce.
- Per skill: SKILL.md up to 1 MB, up to 20 companion files, 10 MB total.
- Uploaded skills do not work on Cowork mobile. Cowork itself does.

Test before you schedule

- Upload one skill, run it once on a quiet week, and read the output before anyone schedules it.
- After editing references/config.md, start a NEW conversation. Changes apply to new sessions only.
- Automated task activity lands in the unified audit log; Purview policies apply.

Microsoft does not validate custom skills created by users.
A skill runs as instructions to the AI, so treat an uploaded file the way you would treat a script. Read SKILL.md before you approve a skill for your organization. Everything in this catalog is plain text and readable in under two minutes.

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